

FutureWorld Robotics

Market Research & Feasibility Assessment

An AI & robotics center — lifelike interactive humanoid robots, youth robotics education, and robot shows. Competitive landscape across the United States, comparable attractions worldwide, and a go / no-go recommendation. (Legal structure undecided; currently leaning for-profit — see Section 6.4.)

Prepared by: Sorphoan (Jack) Ear

Date: June 2, 2026

Scope: U.S. robot exhibits and attractions, lifelike humanoid “robot Tussauds” comparables, youth robotics education, robot-show services, museum-sector economics, a full worldwide market review (Section 8), the competitive pipeline, the 2026 funding climate, and a nonprofit case study. One combined market research document.

Contents

Table of Contents

CONTENTS.....	2
1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY.....	4
<i>Key findings at a glance.....</i>	<i>4</i>
2. THE U.S. ROBOT-MUSEUM LANDSCAPE.....	5
2.1 DEDICATED ROBOT / ROBOTICS-FOCUSED VENUES.....	5
2.2 SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY MUSEUMS WITH NOTABLE ROBOT CONTENT.....	6
2.3 NATIONAL (SMITHSONIAN) AND THEME-PARK ANIMATRONICS.....	7
3. THE “ROBOT MADAME TUSSAUDS” CONCEPT: DOES IT ALREADY EXIST?.....	7
3.1 THE DIRECT PRECEDENT — EX ROBOTS, CHINA.....	7
3.2 THE TECHNOLOGY SUPPLY CHAIN (WHERE YOU WOULD SOURCE FIGURES).....	8
4. KIDS ROBOTICS EDUCATION: A CROWDED MARKET.....	8
4.1 WHO YOU WOULD COMPETE WITH.....	9
4.2 WHERE YOU CAN DIFFERENTIATE.....	9
5. ROBOT SHOWS & PAID INVENTOR DISPLAYS.....	9
5.1 ROBOT-SHOW / RENTAL SERVICES — PROVEN, FRAGMENTED COMPETITION.....	9
5.2 PAID INVENTOR DISPLAYS — WHITE SPACE, BUT UNPROVEN.....	10
6. ECONOMICS, RISK & VIABILITY.....	10
6.1 WHAT IT COSTS TO OPEN.....	10
6.2 HOW THE MONEY COMES IN — AND WHY ADMISSIONS WON’T CARRY IT.....	10
6.3 THE RISK RECORD.....	11
6.4 LEGAL STRUCTURE: FOR-PROFIT VS NONPROFIT (DECISION PENDING).....	11
7. COMPETITION VERDICT & RECOMMENDATION.....	12
7.1 COMPETITION BY LINE OF BUSINESS.....	12
7.2 SHOULD YOU PURSUE IT?.....	13
7.3 SUGGESTED NEXT STEPS.....	13
8. GLOBAL MARKET LANDSCAPE (WORLDWIDE RESEARCH).....	14
8.1 ASIA — THE MOST MATURE MARKET.....	15
<i>China — the closest analog in the world.....</i>	<i>15</i>
<i>Japan — the android pioneer.....</i>	<i>15</i>
<i>South Korea — newest dedicated museum.....</i>	<i>15</i>
<i>Singapore, Taiwan & Hong Kong.....</i>	<i>16</i>
8.2 EUROPE — SUPPLIER HUB, OPEN ATTRACTION NICHE.....	16
<i>Robot museums & landmark exhibits.....</i>	<i>16</i>
<i>Suppliers & the celebrity-android white space.....</i>	<i>17</i>
8.3 MIDDLE EAST & REST OF WORLD.....	17
<i>Middle East — the strongest validation market.....</i>	<i>17</i>
<i>Rest of world.....</i>	<i>18</i>

8.4 GLOBAL MARKET SIZE & INVESTMENT.....	18
<i>Investment flows — the strongest part of the story.....</i>	19
8.5 GLOBAL EDUCATION & ROBOT-SHOW COMPARABLES.....	19
<i>Youth robotics education — a global, willing-to-pay market.....</i>	19
<i>Robot shows, rentals & restaurants.....</i>	19
<i>Paid inventor displays — global white space.....</i>	20
8.6 WHAT THE WORLDWIDE PICTURE MEANS FOR YOU.....	20
9. PIPELINE: IS THE WHITE SPACE ABOUT TO BE FILLED?.....	21
9.1 WHAT IS ACTUALLY IN THE PIPELINE.....	21
9.2 READING THE PIPELINE.....	21
10. EXTERNAL ENVIRONMENT, FUNDING CLIMATE & TIMELINE (2026).....	22
10.1 THE MACRO BACKDROP (MID-2026).....	22
10.2 WHAT THIS MEANS FOR ADMISSIONS (SMALLER EXPOSURE THAN IT SEEMS).....	22
10.3 WHAT THIS MEANS FOR FUNDING (THE REAL EXPOSURE).....	22
10.4 TIMELINE REALITY (~1 YEAR FROM NOW).....	23
11. CASE STUDY: AMERICAN COMPUTER & ROBOTICS MUSEUM.....	23
11.1 FUNDING & GOVERNANCE — THE DURABILITY ENGINE.....	24
11.2 THE SUCCESSION LESSON.....	24
11.3 EDUCATION PROGRAMS — AND THE AWARDS MASTERSTROKE.....	24
11.4 EXHIBITS & INVENTORY — STRONG MODEL, BUT YOUR CONTENT DIVERGES.....	25
11.5 WHAT TO REPLICATE VS. DO DIFFERENTLY.....	25
12. SOURCES.....	26

1. Executive Summary

The verdict: pursue it — but as a serious, education-grade institution, not a novelty attraction, and with eyes open about the capital required. The core concept is timely and the most distinctive piece of it — a “robot Madame Tussauds” of lifelike, AI-conversational celebrity androids — does not yet exist anywhere in the United States. The enabling technology is now commercially available, and the educational-robotics market is growing fast (~27% per year in the U.S.). The legal structure is still open — FutureWorld Robotics is leaning for-profit to tap the surging humanoid-robotics investment market, though a nonprofit route would qualify cleanly for 501(c)(3) status (see Section 6.4). Those are real tailwinds.

The catch: standalone robot attractions have a poor survival record (Tokyo’s Robot Restaurant and Boston’s Spyce both closed), admissions will cover only a small share of costs, and robotics exhibits date quickly. A telling example is that the largest permanent robot exhibit in the U.S. — Carnegie Science Center’s *roboworld* — was retired in 2022 after 13 years; importantly, it was a *planned refresh* by a healthy nonprofit, not a failure, but it shows how fast robotics content ages and how much continual reinvestment a robot venue demands. The project’s biggest external exposure is the **funding climate** (Section 10), which differs by structure: a nonprofit leans on philanthropy (favorable for wealthy donors in 2026 but crowded by competing crises — the Iran war, Ukraine, Ebola), while a for-profit leans on investor capital, currently flooding into humanoid robotics. The concept can work, but only with a flagship lifelike-android differentiator, a diversified revenue model, a sound funding case, and a serious capital base from day one.

Key findings at a glance

Question	Finding
Do robot-dedicated museums already exist in the U.S.?	Rare. Robots appear mostly as exhibits within broader science museums. Only a handful of dedicated/niche venues exist (American Computer & Robotics Museum, Roboland Cleveland, the Bilotta Collection). The famous roboworld exhibit closed in 2022.
Does a “robot Tussauds” of talking celebrity androids exist?	Not in the U.S. or Europe. It exists in China (EX Future Science & Technology Museum, since 2021). The U.S. is open white space for this specific concept.
How high is competition?	Mixed by line of business. Lifelike-android attraction: low (white space). Kids robotics classes: high/saturated. Robot-show rentals: moderate but fragmented. Paid inventor displays: near white space but unproven.

Question	Finding
Is the technology ready?	Yes (2025–26). Silicone-skinned, expressive humanoids (Engineered Arts Ameca, Hanson, EX Robots, Promobot) plus LLM conversation are now productized and purchasable.
For-profit or nonprofit?	Decision pending — leaning for-profit (to raise equity in a hot robotics-investment market). A nonprofit route also works: the IRS recognizes museums as educational/scientific 501(c)(3) orgs and formation is cheap (~\$320–\$700). See Section 6.4.
What is the biggest risk?	Capital + sustainability. Build-out likely \$2M+ before robots; a flagship Ameca adds six figures plus recurring maintenance; admissions cover only ~10–20% of revenue; novelty attractions decay and most museum closures hit in years 1–10.

2. The U.S. Robot-Museum Landscape

The central question — how many U.S. museums have a robot show or robot exhibit — has a clear answer: **truly robot-dedicated museums are rare**. Robots overwhelmingly appear as exhibits inside broader science and technology museums, or as commercial “experience” attractions and toy collections. Below is a census of the venues that matter, grouped by type. Every entry links to its source.

2.1 Dedicated robot / robotics-focused venues

Venue	Location	What it offers	Type
American Computer & Robotics Museum	Bozeman, MT	Oldest computing/Information-Age museum (1990). AI, robotics & automation, Hollywood robot artifacts, early consumer robots. The clearest proof a dedicated robotics nonprofit can endure (35+ yrs). ~\$10 adult.	Nonprofit
Roboland (Roboland US)	Cleveland, OH	A touring commercial robot show (part of the “RoboPark” brand, ~7.5M visitors across 7 countries), not a permanent museum. 50+ interactive robots, 4 daily shows, Sophia and Titan as featured guests. Its own website was offline as of June 2026; link is local news (WKYC) coverage.	Commercial

Venue	Location	What it offers	Type
The Bilotta Collection	Ponte Vedra Beach, FL	~\$7M collection of vintage tin robots and full-size sci-fi replicas (B-9, Robby, Gort). By-appointment, ~\$35/person.	Private
Toy Robot Museum	Adamstown, PA	Was 2,100+ vintage toy robots. Now permanently CLOSED — noted as a data point on novelty-venue fragility.	Closed

2.2 Science & technology museums with notable robot content

This is where most U.S. “robot exhibits” actually live. The strongest current offerings:

Museum	Location	Robot content	Type
Museum of Science, Boston	Boston, MA	“Exploring AI” (2025): Boston Dynamics Spot, retired Atlas, MIT Cheetah; live “Robot Roundup” demos and a Unitree humanoid that plays with visitors. Strongest current offering.	Nonprofit
Computer History Museum	Mountain View, CA	“Chatbots Decoded” (2024) centers on Ameca — a silicone-faced Engineered Arts humanoid that converses with visitors. Best U.S. example of an interactive humanoid.	Nonprofit
MIT Museum	Cambridge, MA	Robotics gallery displays Kismet, the world’s first social robot, plus MIT AI/robotics artifacts.	Nonprofit
The Tech Interactive	San Jose, CA	“Social Robots” exhibit; build/program robots; AI-themed Dream Garden.	Nonprofit
Kamin Science Center	Pittsburgh, PA	Formerly Carnegie Science Center. Its roboworld — once the world’s largest permanent robotics exhibit — was retired in June 2022 after 13 years as a planned refresh (replaced by a Mars exhibit), not a failure. Robot Hall of Fame relocated to a cinema lobby; greeter “Andy” to the main lobby.	Refreshed
Museum of Science & Industry (Griffin MSI)	Chicago, IL	Hosts the touring “Robot Revolution” exhibit (40+ robots, RoboThespian greeter) — not permanent.	Nonprofit

Museum	Location	Robot content	Type
Grand Rapids Public Museum	Grand Rapids, MI	“The Robot Zoo” — eight giant biomechanical “robot” animals plus hands-on activities.	Nonprofit
Great Lakes Science Center	Cleveland, OH	Robotics interactives — gesture-controlled robot arm, remote robotics.	Nonprofit
COSI	Columbus, OH	Remote-controlled robots in a Mars simulator; robotic submersible ROV; robotics programming.	Nonprofit
Liberty Science Center	Jersey City, NJ	Rotating robotics exhibits, live robotic-surgery demos, FIRST robotics events.	Nonprofit

2.3 National (Smithsonian) and theme-park animatronics

- [National Museum of American History](#) (Washington, DC) — holds 9+ historic robots as collection objects (Sandia MARV, iRobot PackBot). Free.
- [National Air & Space / Udvar-Hazy Center](#) — Robonaut 2 (first humanoid in space) and “Stanley,” the DARPA Grand Challenge-winning robot car. Free.
- [Disney — The Hall of Presidents](#) & [Spaceship Earth \(EPCOT\)](#) — the gold standard of lifelike humanoid Audio-Animatronics, but scripted, not conversational AI. Requires park admission.

Takeaway: Across the entire U.S., only two venues genuinely deliver a lifelike, silicone-skinned humanoid that converses with visitors — the Computer History Museum (Ameca) and Roboland Cleveland (Sophia) — and both feature a single, generic android rather than a gallery of recognizable, talking celebrity figures. That gap is the heart of your opportunity.

3. The “Robot Madame Tussauds” Concept: Does It Already Exist?

Short answer: yes — but essentially only in China, and nowhere in the United States. This is the single most important competitive finding in the report, because it defines both the precedent and the white space.

3.1 The direct precedent — EX Robots, China

The Chinese company **EX Robots (EXROBOTS)** has run the [EX Future Science & Technology Museum](#) in Dalian since 2021. State media explicitly describes it as “a robotic version of Madame Tussaud’s wax museum.” It features 30+ silicone bionic-robot figures of famous people — Einstein, Edison, Steve Jobs,

Lu Xun — that move, talk, recite, and converse with visitors. In 2025 the company unveiled a talking [“Li Bai” Tang-poet android](#) whose skin and wrinkles move with speech — a visitor reportedly touched it before realizing it was a machine. This is, almost exactly, the concept you describe — already operating, at scale, abroad.

Notably, the wax-museum incumbent itself has tested the waters: Madame Tussauds Shanghai commissioned its [first robotic silicone figure](#) (actor Jing Boran) from Engineered Arts in 2017–18 — body-scanned, silicone-skinned, with sensors that track visitors’ mood and maintain eye contact.

3.2 The technology supply chain (where you would source figures)

Supplier	What they make	Relevance
Engineered Arts (UK → US)	Ameca & RoboThespian — expressive, conversational humanoids; built the Tussauds Shanghai figure. Restructured into the U.S. and raised \$10M in Dec 2024.	Most likely flagship supplier for a U.S. venue.
Hanson Robotics	Sophia, Einstein, BINA48 — expressive “Frubber” faces; mostly traveling demos and research units.	Proven celebrity/character faces; bespoke pricing.
Promobot (Robo-C)	Mass-marketed androids built to look like any person; ~600 micro-expressions. Explicitly pitched museum use cases.	Off-the-shelf custom likenesses.
EX Robots	The China operator above — also a manufacturer of silicone celebrity bionic figures at scale.	Proof the full concept is buildable today.

Technology maturity (2025–26): Physical realism is mature and purchasable; LLM-driven conversation is now viable, which is the genuinely new capability that makes this concept timely. The hard parts are not the robotics: they are **reliability/uptime** (Japan’s [Henn na Hotel “fired” half its robots](#) for malfunctioning), **AI guardrails** (a celebrity persona on an LLM can go off-brand), and **likeness/voice rights** (Promobot offered \$200K for perpetual rights to a real person’s face/voice — a real cost and legal hurdle, especially for singing and for living celebrities).

4. Kids Robotics Education: A Crowded Market

Your plan to offer short robotics courses and partner with schools sits in a **mature, fast-growing, but saturated** market. The U.S. educational-robotics market is projected to grow from ~\$416M (2024) to ~\$1.66B (2030), a 27.5% CAGR — roughly double the broader STEM-education growth rate (per [Grand View Research](#)). The tailwind is real; so is the competition.

4.1 Who you would compete with

- **Nonprofit competition ecosystems (partners, not rivals):** [FIRST](#) (853,000+ youth in 2024–25) and [VEX / REC Foundation](#) (world’s largest robotics competition). Best treated as partners — host teams, run events, be a feeder.
- **For-profit class franchises (direct rivals, 1,000+ U.S. locations combined):** [Code Ninjas](#) (~350), [Bricks 4 Kidz](#) (~212), [Mad Science](#) (150+), [Snapology](#) (~120), [Engineering For Kids](#) (90+), and premium camp operator [iD Tech](#) (75+ campuses).
- **Science museums already run robotics camps** (Liberty Science Center, The Works, MSI, AMNH and others) — so “a museum that teaches robotics” is not itself a differentiator.

4.2 Where you can differentiate

Museums monetize education heavily and legitimately — earned income is ~32% of museum revenue, summer camps alone can generate \$100K–\$400K/season, and weekly camp fees run \$250–\$450/child (per the [Association of Children’s Museums](#)). The differentiators that are genuinely uncommon:

1. **The roadmap/pipeline into robotics engineering.** Most franchises sell discrete classes; few offer a credible, articulated progression tied to real institutions. Your school-partnership roadmap is the white space — not the classes themselves.
2. **Exhibits + courses.** Franchises run from strip-malls. Pairing authentic, large-scale robot exhibits with instruction is something they cannot replicate.
3. **Nonprofit access/equity** — sliding-scale pricing, grants, underserved-community reach.

5. Robot Shows & Paid Inventor Displays

5.1 Robot-show / rental services — proven, fragmented competition

Robot entertainment is a real, growing business. The U.S. entertainment-humanoid market was ~\$135M in 2024 with a projected ~37% CAGR (per [Market.us](#)). The field is competitive but fragmented:

- **Branded acts & agencies:** [Titan the Robot](#) (the flagship 8ft entertainer, 30+ countries), [RoboThespian](#), and agencies like [Scarlett Entertainment](#) and [Altus Entertainment](#).
- **Humanoid rental firms:** [Engineered Arts \(Ameca/RoboThespian rental\)](#), [Advanced Robot Solutions \(US\)](#), [Robot-Rentals.com](#) (Pepper, NAO), [PROVEN Robotics](#). Indicative pricing: Pepper-class ~\$3,800–\$5,400/day; Ameca premium/quote-only.
- **Robots as venue attractions:** [Sphere Las Vegas “Aura” robots](#) and the wave of [robot servers in U.S. restaurants](#) prove strong consumer pull for “robot as the experience.”

Strategic note: a center that owns a humanoid fleet can amortize that hardware across exhibits, in-house shows, and external rentals — a structural advantage over one-off rental firms.

5.2 Paid inventor displays — white space, but unproven

No established U.S. permanent venue charges inventors to display robots. The only clear price precedent is [Maker Faire’s commercial booth fees](#) (\$500 commercial / \$1,500 startup), and those are event-based and partly subsidized by free educational makers. Dedicated invention museums like the [National Inventors Hall of Fame](#) are free and curated, not pay-to-display. This line is novel (low competition) but unproven as a money-maker — inventors typically expect free exposure. Treat it as a secondary/marketing stream, not a core pillar.

6. Economics, Risk & Viability

6.1 What it costs to open

Cost item	Figure	Source
Museum-quality construction	~\$700–\$1,600 / sq ft	Museum Planner
Renovation / fit-out of existing space	\$250–\$600 / sq ft	Solutions GC
Interactive science-center exhibits	\$300–\$550+ / sq ft	Museum Planner
Worked example: 9,000 sq ft venue	~\$2.475M to open	Museum Planner
Flagship humanoid — Ameca (Engineered Arts)	~\$100K–\$500K+ each, quote-only; ~\$150K–\$250K typical	Engineered Arts
Pepper (cheaper, but discontinued)	~\$32K buy / ~\$671/mo	RobotLAB
501(c)(3) formation (incorporation + IRS)	~\$320–\$700 total	Form1023.org

Bottom line on capital: a modest interactive build-out realistically lands in the low single-digit millions before a single robot is purchased; each flagship lifelike android adds six figures plus recurring licensing, vendor servicing, and maintenance.

6.2 How the money comes in — and why admissions won’t carry it

The closest sector benchmark — museums — runs on contributed income (grants, donations, sponsorships) plus earned income, with **admissions only ~10–20% of total revenue** (per [Sotheby’s Institute](#) and [AAM](#)). The implication depends on structure: a **nonprofit** must build a donor/grant base from day one (~60%+ of revenue); a **for-profit** funds the build with equity and debt and lives on earned revenue (shows, rentals, education, retail, admissions), trading away grants and tax-deductible donations

for access to the investment market and the ability to return profit. Either way, **ticket sales alone cannot carry the venue** — earned revenue must be diversified across shows, rentals, education, and retail.

6.3 The risk record

- **Most museum closures happen in years 1–10** — the early years are the danger zone (per [AASLH](#)). The most common founder trap is underestimating the cost to run and maintain the institution.
- **Commercial novelty robot ventures are fragile:** Tokyo’s famous [Robot Restaurant closed in 2020](#); Boston’s [Spyce robotic kitchen closed](#) its original location. These were for-profit attractions undone by tourism collapse and a pivot, respectively.
- **Robotics exhibits age fast — budget for continual refresh:** Carnegie Science Center’s roboworld — the largest permanent robot exhibit in the U.S. — was *retired in 2022 after 13 years*. This was **not a failure**: the center is a healthy nonprofit and director Jason Brown explained the [technology had changed and it was time to keep experiences relevant](#) (the robots were relocated, not scrapped). The lesson is novelty/relevance decay — even a well-run robot exhibit ages out and needs ongoing reinvestment, a recurring cost a robotics center must plan for.
- **Attendance has not fully recovered:** only ~45% of U.S. museums are back to pre-pandemic attendance, and families (your core audience) are the slowest-returning segment (per [AAM 2025](#)). Repeat visitation is the documented weak point — which matters because novelty decays.
- **The encouraging counter-example:** the [American Computer & Robotics Museum](#) has thrived for 35+ years as an educational nonprofit, and robotics-as-exhibit thrives inside major science centers.
- **Important caveat — AI weakens the historical failure pattern.** The biggest single killer of these ventures was *novelty decay and stale, scripted content* — visitors came once and didn’t return. That is precisely the failure mode that today’s AI-driven robots neutralize: a humanoid that can learn a new dance in hours, perform a different act each visit, and hold open-ended conversation refreshes its own content continuously (as China’s Unitree humanoids now do on live television). So the old lesson is *not* “robot entertainment is doomed.” The fairer reading: AI has solved the content-staleness problem, but the *business* fundamentals that sank these ventures still decide success — capital intensity, location and foot-traffic economics, tourism dependence, reliability in a public setting, and (new with conversational AI) likeness rights and guardrails against off-brand speech. Diversified revenue, an educational core, good location, and continually refreshed programming remain the determinants.

6.4 Legal structure: for-profit vs nonprofit (decision pending)

FutureWorld Robotics has not finalized its legal structure and is currently **leaning for-profit**. Both are viable; the choice mainly shapes funding, taxes, and governance rather than the market opportunity. The trade-offs:

Factor	For-profit (leaning)	Nonprofit (alternative)
Capital	Equity / VC + debt; can sell ownership stakes. Robotics investment is booming (\$3.7B into humanoids in 2025).	Grants, donations, sponsorships (~60%+ of revenue); no equity sale.
Taxes	Pays corporate tax; no exemption.	501(c)(3) tax-exempt; donations are tax-deductible.
Profit	Can distribute profit to founders/investors; equity upside.	No private profit; surplus must be reinvested in the mission.
Speed & control	Faster to stand up; founder retains control and upside.	Board-governed and mission-locked; more compliance.
Best-fit funders	Robotics VCs, strategic/industry investors, family offices.	STEM-education foundations, philanthropists, corporate giving.
Main risk	Investors expect returns and an exit; a capital-intensive attraction must show a credible path to profit.	Donor acquisition is hard in arts/culture and crowded by crisis-era giving (Section 10).

Recommendation: given the surge of capital into humanoid robotics and your preference, for-profit is a credible lead option. But the educational mission (kids robotics, school partnerships) is an asset under either structure, and a **hybrid** is worth considering — a for-profit attraction with an affiliated nonprofit education arm — to capture both investment and grant/donation funding. Decide early with a startup/nonprofit attorney, because the choice affects fundraising, taxes, and how likeness-rights contracts are written.

7. Competition Verdict & Recommendation

7.1 Competition by line of business

Line of business	Competition	Read
Lifelike celebrity-android attraction	LOW (white space)	No U.S. or European equivalent. Exists only in China. Your strongest differentiator.
Robots-as-exhibit (general)	MODERATE	Many science museums have robot exhibits, but none is robot-dedicated. Room for a focused venue.

Line of business	Competition	Read
Kids robotics courses	HIGH (saturated)	1,000+ franchise locations + museum camps. Differentiate via roadmap + exhibits, not the classes themselves.
Robot-show / rental services	MODERATE	Proven, growing, fragmented. Owning a fleet is a structural edge.
Paid inventor displays	LOW (unproven)	Near white space, but no proven money-maker. Keep secondary.

7.2 Should you pursue it?

Yes — conditionally. The concept is timely, the flagship differentiator is genuine white space in the U.S., the technology is ready, and either legal structure can work (you're leaning for-profit; see Section 6.4). But the venture is capital-intensive and sits in a category with a real failure record. Pursue it only if you can satisfy these conditions:

4. **Lead with the lifelike-android “robot Tussauds” experience** as the signature draw — it is what nobody else in the U.S. has. The other elements (courses, shows, inventor spots) are supporting revenue, not the headline.
5. **Position as educational/scientific, not novelty.** This is the historically durable positioning, and it keeps the nonprofit option (cleanest path to 501(c)(3)) open if you choose it.
6. **Line up capital before opening.** For a for-profit, that means equity investors (the robotics-investment market is hot right now); for a nonprofit, grants and donors (~60%+ of revenue). Either way, treat admissions as only ~10–20% and diversify earned revenue across shows, rentals, and education.
7. **Diversify revenue across five streams** — admission, education, in-house robot shows + fleet rentals, facility/event rentals, and café/retail — so no single line carries the center.
8. **Plan for reliability and AI guardrails from day one.** Lifelike robots break and misbehave; budget for maintenance staff, graceful failure modes, and constrained conversational AI. Use seated/torso figures (reliable) over full-body locomotion (still demo-stage).
9. **Secure likeness/voice rights early** for any real celebrity figures — a material cost and legal hurdle, especially for living people and singing performances. Consider public-domain historical figures (Einstein, Edison, Tesla, Lincoln) first.

7.3 Suggested next steps

- Validate demand with a small pilot — e.g., a single rented Ameca plus one or two celebrity-likeness figures in a pop-up or partner-museum residency — before committing to a permanent build.
- Get written pricing and maintenance/licensing terms from Engineered Arts, Hanson, Promobot, and EX Robots so the capital and operating models rest on real numbers.

- Engage a startup/nonprofit attorney to choose and form the legal entity (for-profit vs 501(c)(3), or a hybrid) and structure likeness-rights agreements.
- Build a founding board and a development (fundraising) lead before signing a lease.

8. Global Market Landscape (Worldwide Research)

Beyond the U.S., a full worldwide review was conducted across Asia, Europe, the Middle East, and the rest of the world. **The headline finding: the complete concept already exists — but only in China.** EX Robots' EX Future Science & Technology Museum (Dalian, since 2021) bundles lifelike silicone celebrity/historical androids, a museum, on-site R&D and education into one operation the press calls “a robotic version of Madame Tussauds.” No venue in the U.S., Europe, the Middle East, or the rest of Asia has combined these into a single attraction — everywhere else the pieces exist separately. The at-a-glance summary is below, followed by the full regional detail, global market-size data, and worldwide comparables.

Region	Key takeaway
China	Most mature. The direct analog (EX Robots), the world's best celebrity-android tech, a humanoid “4S store” (Beijing Robot Mall), mandated school AI/robotics, and billions in state funding.
Japan	Android pioneer (Ishiguro's Geminoid , Miraikan's androids, Erica the “actress” robot). Cautionary tales: Robot Restaurant closed (2020); Henn na Hotel cut half its robots (2019).
South Korea	The Seoul Robot & AI Museum opened 2024 (world's first dedicated Robot & AI museum). Masan Robot Land runs deficits — a content-quality warning.
Europe	The Robot Museum Madrid (200+ robots) proves a standalone robot museum can sustain. UK is the supplier/show hub. The celebrity-android attraction niche is open white space.
Middle East	Strongest validation market: Dubai Museum of the Future (Ameca), Sophia's Saudi citizenship, homegrown androids, and tens of billions in sovereign AI/robotics investment.
Rest of world	Robot-as-attraction monetizes (TELUS Spark robot coaster , Canada; UAE RoboCafe; India robot restaurants) but novelty fatigue and venue fragility (Ontario Science Centre closure) are real risks.

8.1 Asia — the most mature market

Nearly every component of the concept already exists somewhere in Asia, but in fragmented form. China is the only place one operator has bundled lifelike androids, a venue, education, and a paid R&D/retail showcase into a single replicable model.

China — the closest analog in the world

- **EX Future Science & Technology Museum (EX Robots), Dalian** — the single closest analog. Opened 2021; 30+ interactive bionic humanoids; press calls it “a robotic version of Madame Tussauds.” Has “resurrected” Einstein, Edison, Hawking and Tang poet Li Bai as talking silicone androids. Expanding toward a stated goal of **100 robot museums in 100 cities** as cultural-tourism complexes (exhibits + playground + training + robot café). [Venue](#) · [Li Bai android \(China Daily\)](#).
- **Suzhou Robot Science & Technology Museum (CreaThink)** — built by Ecovacs; exhibition + learning + research + tourism; uses Engineered Arts humanoids. [Engineered Arts](#).
- **Robot Mall, Beijing E-Town** — world’s first humanoid-robot “4S store” (Aug 2025); ~4,000 m², 50+ brands, 100+ robots to test/buy. A retail-experiential hybrid directly relevant to your paid-display idea. [Beijing.gov](#).
- **Education & funding:** from Sept 2025, Beijing mandates ≥8 hours/year of AI lessons from age 6; Hangzhou ≥10 hours. City robotics funds include Shenzhen (~US\$1.4B), Beijing (US\$1.4B), Shanghai (US\$14B target). [NPR](#).
- **Robot shows:** Unitree humanoids performed at the 2025 CCTV Spring Festival Gala; four robotics firms signed Gala deals worth ~US\$14M. [SCMP](#).

Japan — the android pioneer

- **Miraikan (Tokyo)** has displayed Hiroshi Ishiguro’s androids Otonaroid and Kodomoroid since 2014 — the canonical android museum exhibit. [New Atlas](#).
- **Ishiguro / Geminoid** — silicone teleoperated doppelgänger androids, the world reference for realism. [IEEE Spectrum](#). **Erica** converses on 80+ topics, worked as a TV announcer, and was cast as lead in a film. [HuffPost](#).
- **Celebrity “resurrection” precedent:** NHK + Yamaha recreated late singer Misora Hibari as a hologram performing a new song (2019) — a strong precedent and a cautionary one (some called it “blasphemy”). [Japan Times](#).
- **Cautionary tales:** [Robot Restaurant closed in 2020](#); [Henn na Hotel cut half its 243 robots in 2019](#) for underperformance.

South Korea — newest dedicated museum

- **Seoul Robot & AI Museum (RAIM)** opened Oct 2024 — billed as the world’s first dedicated Robot & AI museum; 7,400 m²; admission ~2,000 KRW (free for youth). [Visit Seoul](#).
- **Masan Robot Land (Changwon)** — first robot theme park (2019, 256 robots) but *running daily deficits* amid weak content — a direct warning that hardware alone doesn’t sustain attendance. [Visit Korea](#).

- **Korea leads AI-hologram celebrity resurrection** (Mnet recreations of Kim Kwang-seok and others), with documented ethics debate. [CNN](#). World's highest robot density (~1,012/10,000 workers); 4th Intelligent Robot Plan commits >US\$2.24B.

Singapore, Taiwan & Hong Kong

- **Singapore:** no dedicated android museum (white space). Science Centre Singapore's Smart Nation PlayScape and [RoboFest 2026](#) (featuring Ameca) anchor the scene; National Robotics Programme ~S\$635M (2022–25).
- **Hong Kong:** home of Hanson Robotics (maker of Sophia) — a lab, not a museum; Madame Tussauds HK pioneered silicone animatronic celebrity figures (Andy Lau with a heartbeat). [Hanson](#).
- **Taiwan:** Sha Yang Ye Robot Wonderland (Taoyuan), a corporate robot-themed attraction. [Taoyuan tourism](#).

8.2 Europe — supplier hub, open attraction niche

Robot museums & landmark exhibits

Venue	Country	What it offers	Status
The Robot Museum (Museo del Robot)	Spain (Madrid)	Closest standalone analog. 200+ robots, guided tours, live demos, shop, rotating exhibits; expanded to 1,200 m ² in 2025. Collection is film-prop/historical, not celebrity androids.	Open
Science Museum — “Robots” exhibition	UK (London)	Blockbuster 2017 exhibition; 100+ robots, 500-year history, RoboThespian performing every 20 min; toured multiple cities to 2021. Proves strong public demand for humanoid exhibitions.	Toured
Heinz Nixdorf MuseumsForum	Germany	World's largest computer museum; AI & robotics section; visitors compare Ameca, Nadine and Pepper side by side.	Open
Copernicus Science Centre — Robotic Theatre	Poland	Three RoboThespian humanoids perform a Stanisław Lem play — the strongest European precedent for a paid robot-show experience.	Open
Deutsches Museum — Robotics	Germany	Permanent robotics exhibition (since 2022); live arena demos; holds an Ameca unit.	Open

Venue	Country	What it offers	Status
Cité des Sciences — “Robots”	France (Paris)	900 m ² permanent exhibition; 20+ robots including French-origin NAO and Pepper.	Open
National Robotarium	UK (Edinburgh)	UK national robotics/AI centre (£22.4m); mainly R&D, opens to public for events; houses an Ameca.	Open

Suppliers & the celebrity-android white space

- **Engineered Arts (UK)** — the most relevant supplier: Ameca, RoboThespian, and the **Mesmer** silicone-skin technology (3D-scanned from real people) used to build Madame Tussauds Shanghai’s moving figure. [Mesmer](#).
- **Ai-Da (UK)** — ultra-realistic robot artist; exhibited at the Design Museum, Venice Biennale, V&A, the Pyramids of Giza. [Exhibitions](#). **PAL Robotics (Spain)** and the former **Aldebaran (France, Pepper/NAO)** round out European humanoid supply — though Aldebaran’s 2025 bankruptcy is a cautionary note. [Aldebaran](#).
- **Madame Tussauds is already edging in:** its Amsterdam venue unveiled a moving silicone robot figure (kickboxer Rico Verhoeven). But no European venue has built a full celebrity-android attraction — the niche is **open white space**, with mature European supply. [Merlin](#).
- **Robot shows:** [Titan the Robot \(Cyberstein, UK\)](#) performs in 50+ countries; [Robots of London](#) and Scarlett Entertainment supply rentals.
- **Education caution:** FIRST LEGO League ends after the 2026–27 season (LEGO did not renew); RoboCupJunior, VEX, and EU-funded programs are more durable partners. EU has committed multi-billion-euro AI/robotics funding (EU AI, Data & Robotics Partnership €2.6B; InvestAI €200B).

8.3 Middle East & rest of world

Middle East — the strongest validation market

- **Dubai Museum of the Future** — the most relevant regional comparable; hosts Ameca (upgraded 2025, speaks 6+ languages incl. Arabic) as an intelligent guide, plus a robodog and robot barista. [Blooploop](#).
- **Sophia’s Saudi citizenship (2017)** — the landmark proof that a lifelike android generates outsized global media. [WEE](#). Homegrown androids **Sara & Mohammad** (QSS AI, Riyadh) show Gulf appetite for branded humanoids. [IoT World Today](#).
- **RoboCafe Dubai** (UAE’s first fully robotic café) and the Dubai Police humanoid program (goal: 25% robotic force by 2030) are high-visibility public android-interaction precedents. [RoboCafe](#).

- **Sovereign investment is enormous:** Saudi PIF’s HUMAIN (>US\$100B planned, NVIDIA Omniverse for “physical AI and robotics”); UAE’s MGX (~US\$100B target). National AI curricula in both the UAE (Strategy 2031) and Saudi (Vision 2030, VEX partnership reaching 6M+ students). [PIF/HUMAIN](#).

Rest of world

- **Canada — TELUS Spark (Calgary)** operates RO5iE, Canada’s first indoor robot roller coaster (a paid robot-as-attraction model), plus a Boston Dynamics robo-dog. [RO5iE](#). Caution: the [Ontario Science Centre closed abruptly in 2024](#) over building issues.
- **Australia — Questacon** (RoboThespian + Pepper) and the touring “Born or Built?” robotics exhibition; the new National Communication Museum (Melbourne) was launched by Sophia — a celebrity-android driving attendance. [Questacon](#).
- **India — robot restaurants** (Chennai, 2017; now Bengaluru/Coimbatore) are big kid/selfie draws but show novelty fatigue over time. Education is huge: government Atal Tinkering Labs reach 11M+ students. [ATL \(PIB\)](#).
- **Latin America & Africa** — education/industrial focus, no marquee android attraction; rising robotics-curriculum programs (Tec de Monterrey; South Africa’s national Coding & Robotics curriculum; Nigeria’s CogLabs with UNESCO/Google).

8.4 Global market size & investment

A credibility note for investors: third-party market-size base values vary by an order of magnitude across research firms (e.g., “entertainment robots 2025” ranged from ~\$3B to ~\$44B). Lead with growth rates and bank/industry-body figures; treat vendor market-size estimates as ranges.

Market	Size / projection	Source
Humanoid robots (bank view)	Goldman Sachs: ~\$38B TAM by 2035. Morgan Stanley: ~\$5T by 2050, ~1B+ units.	Goldman · Morgan Stanley
Entertainment robots	~\$3B–\$44B (2025, definitions vary); consensus CAGR ~21–27%.	Precedence
Educational / STEM robots	~\$1.4B–\$2.1B base (2023–26); CAGR ~15–26% (most ~18–22%). APAC fastest-growing.	Grand View
Service robots	~\$47B–\$66B (2023–24) → ~\$108B–\$173B (2030); CAGR ~12–21%.	Grand View
Museums (global)	~\$57–\$59B (2023–24) → ~\$76B (2030); CAGR ~4–6%.	GMInsights
Theme parks / attractions	~\$68–\$69B (2023–25) → ~\$110–\$139B (2033–34); CAGR ~6–7%. IP-based parks lead.	Grand View

Market	Size / projection	Source
Experience economy	Heading to ~\$2.1T by 2032; ~75% of consumers value experiences over products.	Empower

Investment flows — the strongest part of the story

- **Private capital is flooding in:** Figure AI reached a **\$39B valuation** (Sept 2025); Apptronik ~\$5B; humanoid-specific funding hit ~\$3.7B across 26 deals in 2025, capturing >40% of all robotics funding. [Figure](#) · [Crunchbase](#).
- **Your core supplier is funded:** Engineered Arts (Ameca/RoboThespian) raised \$10M in Dec 2024 and supplies the Museum of the Future and the Las Vegas Sphere — de-risking the lifelike-android line. [VentureBeat](#).
- **Sovereign/government money is vast:** China is reported to be steering up to ~¥1 trillion (~US\$138B) into robotics/AI over 20 years; the EU has committed multi-billion-euro programs; Saudi's HUMAIN >US\$100B. [IFR](#).
- **Attendance context:** the TEA/AECOM 2024 index shows top-25 theme-park attendance back to ~246M (up 2.4%), and notably **14 of the world's top-20 museums are now in China**. Immersion, storytelling and novelty are the documented drivers of visitation — favorable for a lifelike-android hook. [TEA/AECOM](#).

8.5 Global education & robot-show comparables

Youth robotics education — a global, willing-to-pay market

- **Competition platforms span the globe:** [FIRST](#) (~200 countries), [VEX/REC](#) (20,000+ teams, ~50–70 countries, 1.1M+ students), [World Robot Olympiad](#) (70k–100k youth, 95+ countries), [Robotex International](#) (Estonia, 17+ countries), and China's televised [DJI RoboMaster](#).
- **Willingness-to-pay is high:** FIRST's FRC season registration is \$6,300 plus kits and per-event fees — team budgets routinely exceed \$10,000.
- **Global franchises prove the model:** [Algorithmics](#) (100+ countries, 515+ partners, 1.1M+ taught), [Makeblock](#) (140+ countries, 6M+ users), [RoboThink](#) (23 countries).
- **Government mandates create tailwinds:** China (AI/robotics in 50% of schools target; 8h/yr from age 6), South Korea (AI across all grades by 2025), Singapore (IMDA programs), India (Atal Tinkering Labs, 11M+ students). [Fortune](#).

Robot shows, rentals & restaurants

- **The global anchor act:** [Titan the Robot](#) (53+ countries; theme parks, festivals, corporate). Rental benchmark: a Pepper-class humanoid rents for ~\$3,800–\$5,400/day (e.g., [Robots of London](#)).

- **Robot restaurants worldwide** (Alibaba Robot.He 100+ stores, JD X Cafe in China; ~3,000 serving robots in Korea by 2023) show consumer acceptance — but the Tokyo Robot Restaurant’s closure warns against tourism-dependent, show-only models.

Paid inventor displays — global white space

Across major robot expos worldwide — [World Robot Conference \(Beijing\)](#), [World Robot Summit \(Japan\)](#), and CES — the universal model is “exhibitor pays” for short-duration booths. There is **no established global precedent for a permanent venue that charges individual inventors to display prototypes on an ongoing basis**. For your concept this is genuine white space — pioneering rather than copying — but, as in the U.S., it is unproven and best treated as a secondary revenue line.

8.6 What the worldwide picture means for you

10. **The concept is proven, not crowded.** China’s EX Robots demonstrates the full model works and draws visitors; no Western equivalent exists. A U.S./Western celebrity-android attraction would be a first-mover, not a me-too.
11. **Every input is globally available.** Lifelike androids (Engineered Arts UK, Hanson HK, Promobot, EX Robots, PAL Spain), curricula (Algorithmics, Makeblock, VEX, WRO), and show acts (Titan) can all be sourced — you are assembling proven components, not inventing them.
12. **The macro tailwinds are bank-validated.** Goldman (\$38B by 2035) and Morgan Stanley (\$5T by 2050) both raised humanoid forecasts; the experience economy is heading to \$2.1T. FutureWorld Robotics monetizes public fascination during the 2026–2035 novelty window.
13. **The global failure pattern is consistent and avoidable.** Robot Restaurant (closed), Henn na Hotel (de-roboticized), Masan Robot Land (deficits) all failed on the same axes: novelty fatigue, tourism dependence, weak/unchanging content, and reliability. The fix is diversified revenue, an educational core, and a continual-refresh budget.
14. **Two things to handle early:** celebrity likeness/voice rights (a real cost and legal hurdle globally — note the Misora Hibari “blasphemy” and Korean ethics debates) and operational reliability/AI guardrails. Public-domain historical figures (Einstein, Edison, Tesla, Lincoln) are the lowest-risk starting roster.

In short, worldwide research strengthens the case: the idea is validated abroad, the Western market is open, the supply chain is mature and funded, and the documented overseas failures point to a clear, avoidable set of mistakes — the same diversified, education-anchored, continually-refreshed model recommended in Section 7.

9. Pipeline: Is the White Space About to Be Filled?

Because today's gap could close, a dedicated forward-looking scan was run for **announced, funded, or in-development** robotics museums and exhibits — the future competition, not the current landscape.

The reassuring headline: the dedicated U.S. “robot Tussauds” niche is not being directly filled. No firm announcement of a new standalone humanoid/android museum opening in the U.S. in 2025–2026 was found. The pipeline threats are mostly *adjacent*, not head-on.

9.1 What is actually in the pipeline

Who	What's planned	Threat level
EX Robots (China)	Stated goal of 100 robot museums in 100 cities (2 open, 20+ cities in talks). The only entity executing your exact concept at scale — but China-focused, no announced U.S. site.	HIGH if it crosses to the U.S.; currently low domestically
Madame Tussauds / Merlin	Moving silicone figures rolling out (Shanghai, Amsterdam, London); Merlin's stated next stage is AI/holographic figures guests can converse with. No dated rollout yet.	HIGHEST conceptual overlap — watch closely
U.S. science centers (Kamin, Liberty Science Center, Tech Interactive, Exploratorium, MOS Boston)	Well-funded expansions layering in AI/robotics content (e.g., Kamin's \$65M reimagining; Liberty's funded 100k+ sq ft “Project Supernova”). None building a dedicated lifelike-android attraction.	MODERATE — could absorb general demand
Disney BDX droids & Sphere “Aura”	Disney scaling autonomous Star Wars droids globally; Sphere's Aura humanoids already greet guests in Las Vegas (closest U.S. “lifelike interactive humanoid” precedent operating now).	LOW–MODERATE — normalizes robots, raises expectations
Gulf (Dubai, Riyadh, Abu Dhabi)	Hot zone for new humanoid attractions — Dubai Museum of the Future upgrades, Riyadh's Nov 2025 “Humanoid Lounge” showroom, Sphere Abu Dhabi (~2029). Not U.S. competitors.	LOW for U.S.; signals global momentum

9.2 Reading the pipeline

Two near-term risks are worth actively monitoring: a **Merlin / Madame Tussauds AI-conversational figure attraction** (the most conceptually overlapping incumbent, with the brand, sites, and supplier access to move fast) and an **EX Robots U.S. entry**. The strongest *structural* pressure is the wave of well-funded U.S. science-center expansions bundling robotics into broader STEM — they won't replicate a celebrity-android attraction, but they compete for the same family and school audiences. Note too that the enabling suppliers (Engineered Arts, now expanding in the U.S.; Realbotix) sell to anyone, so the barrier to a fast-follower is the concept, brand, and execution — not the hardware. **Practical implication:** the window is open now but not indefinitely; first-mover advantage, a distinctive brand, and locked-in likeness/partnership deals are how you defend it.

10. External Environment, Funding Climate & Timeline (2026)

Whether FutureWorld Robotics is structured as a for-profit or nonprofit, its viability depends far more on the **funding climate** than on ticket affordability — but the relevant climate differs: **investor capital** for a for-profit, **philanthropy** for a nonprofit. This section covers both, plus current economic and world conditions as of mid-2026. *(This is contextual information, not financial advice.)*

10.1 The macro backdrop (mid-2026)

- **Economy — cooling, not collapsing:** U.S. GDP is growing ~2.2% but consumer spending is slowing to ~2.1%, inflation sits at ~3.8% (above target, pushed by tariffs), lower-income households are squeezed, and Goldman Sachs puts the 12-month recession probability near 30%. [Goldman Sachs · S&P Global](#).
- **Geopolitical shock:** the [2026 Iran war](#) (since Feb 2026) and disruption to the Strait of Hormuz, plus the ongoing Ukraine war, are elevating oil prices, market volatility, and global uncertainty.
- **Public health / travel:** the WHO declared an Ebola public-health emergency in May 2026, and the U.S. imposed [temporary entry restrictions](#) on travelers from three African nations — a drag on international travel sentiment.

10.2 What this means for admissions (smaller exposure than it seems)

Affordability pressure on families is real, but admissions are only ~10–20% of museum revenue, and the documented weak point is *repeat* visitation — which a soft economy worsens. The strategic response is to anchor the audience in **local residents and school groups, not tourists**: tourism is the most exposed to travel bans and instability, and tourism dependence is exactly what sank Tokyo's Robot Restaurant. A local, education-anchored base is more recession-resilient (the “staycation” effect) and less exposed to the Ebola/travel-ban dynamic.

10.3 What this means for funding (the real exposure)

- **For-profit path (where you're leaning) — the climate is strongly in your favor:** investor capital is flooding into robotics — ~\$3.7B into humanoids in 2025, Figure AI at a \$39B valuation — so the relevant funding market is far healthier than the philanthropic one right now. The catch is that investors expect returns and an exit, so a capital-intensive attraction with ~10–20% admission economics must show a credible path to profit via shows, fleet rentals, education, licensing, and retail. [Crunchbase](#).
- **Nonprofit path — the good news:** on paper, 2026 is one of the more favorable individual-philanthropy environments in decades — strong markets, a historic generational wealth transfer, and tax-law changes adding breaks for standard-deduction donors. Arts & culture fundraising stayed strong through 2025 even as audiences softened. [CCS Fundraising](#) · [Foundation Source](#).
- **Nonprofit path — the headwind:** donor acquisition is hardest in arts & culture, and competing crises (the Iran war, Ukraine, Ebola) pull philanthropic dollars toward urgent humanitarian relief and away from new, discretionary cultural projects. A brand-new, capital-intensive robotics center competes for attention against war and disease relief. Market volatility from the oil/Iran shock can also dent foundation endowments, which set grant budgets with a lag. [Chronicle of Philanthropy](#).
- **The implication:** if you raise from investors, lead with the *commercial and technology story* (a first-mover Western android attraction riding the humanoid-robotics wave, with a diversified earned-revenue model); if you raise philanthropically, lead with the *educational and charitable mission* (STEM access for kids, school partnerships), which competes far better for crisis-era giving than “entertainment.” A hybrid lets you tell both stories to the right audiences.

10.4 Timeline reality (~1 year from now)

A ~12-month horizon (launch around mid-2027) is realistic for **setup** — incorporating the entity (for-profit or 501(c)(3)), building a board, securing likeness/partnership letters of intent, and running a pilot — but it is **ambitious for raising multi-million capital**, whether from investors or a donor campaign (both commonly take longer than a year). The practical path is to **decouple the two**: within ~12 months, run a low-cost pilot (a rented Ameca plus one or two figures in a partner venue or pop-up) to prove demand and attract investors or anchor donors, then let the full build follow as the raise matures. Helpfully, forecasts have inflation easing toward ~2.6% by end-2026, so conditions may improve into your build window — but the period of elevated uncertainty is now, which argues for a capital-light start.

11. Case Study: American Computer & Robotics Museum

The [American Computer & Robotics Museum](#) (ACRM) in Bozeman, Montana is the best available proof that a robotics-themed nonprofit can endure — founded 1990, it is described as the world's oldest continually operating computing-history museum and is rated the **#1 thing to do in Bozeman** on TripAdvisor. E.O. Wilson called it “inch for inch, the best museum in the world.” It is the right institution

to learn from — but with one important distinction: ACRM is a *history* museum of static artifacts in a small college town, whereas your concept is a cutting-edge, interactive AI-android attraction. The transferable lessons are therefore mostly in how it is *governed and funded*, not what it displays.

11.1 Funding & governance — the durability engine

ACRM runs on a small budget (roughly \$350K–\$550K/year), carries almost no debt, and is sustained overwhelmingly by **philanthropy, not gate receipts**. In most years 75–98% of revenue is contributions; admission and programs are only ~8–12%. If you choose the nonprofit route, this is the single most important lesson: a niche museum lives on a committed donor and member base, exactly as Section 10 concluded. (For a for-profit the parallel lesson is the same lean cost discipline, but with earned revenue and investor capital in place of contributions.) Its Form 990 history also shows disciplined, lean management — reserves (net assets) roughly doubled from ~\$335K (2012) to ~\$729K (2025).

FY	Revenue	Expenses	Net assets	Contributions %
2025	\$440,626	\$459,364	\$729,313	76.7%
2024	\$545,554	\$417,764	\$721,313	80.5%
2023	\$357,065	\$378,792	\$563,008	73.4%
2021	\$313,953	\$262,906	\$582,560	84.1%
2019	\$329,945	\$212,510	\$511,648	97.9%
2018	\$197,342	\$172,410	\$381,572	91.3%

Source: [ProPublica Nonprofit Explorer \(EIN 81-0460318\)](#) and ACRM’s own published 990s.

- **Lean, professionalized structure:** a working board of ~10–12 uncompensated directors, a salaried Executive Director (Eleanor Barker), modest staff, and heavy volunteer support. Board members have included [Federico Faggin](#) (co-inventor of the Intel 4004) — credibility that helps fundraising.
- **Anchored to a university and community:** located one block from Montana State University, it draws on the university’s foot traffic and intellectual community, co-presents its awards “with support from MSU,” and the founder sat on MSU’s CS/engineering advisory board. A [university or tech-employer partnership](#) is a replicable anchor for your center.

11.2 The succession lesson

Founder George Keremedjiev died in November 2018. The museum **survived and then grew** because it was never a one-person operation: his widow Barbara stepped in as Board President, an Executive Director already ran daily operations, and an active board was in place. It briefly closed, reopened in January 2019, and revenue rose from ~\$197K (2018) to ~\$440–545K (2024–25). **The lesson: build institutional capacity — a real board, a paid director, documented processes — from the start, so the museum does not depend on any single founder.** [Billings Gazette](#).

11.3 Education programs — and the awards masterstroke

- **Programs:** school field trips and tours, a [STEM Summer Camp](#), and hands-on [“IdeaLab” classes](#) — directly relevant to your kids-robotics-roadmap pillar.
- **The Stibitz-Wilson Awards (the model to copy):** since 1997, ACRM has given an annual award honoring computing and biology pioneers — honorees include Nobel laureates Jennifer Doudna and Jack Kilby, Turing winner Robert Metcalfe, and Ralph Baer and Federico Faggin. [This single program](#) links a tiny Montana museum to world-class scientists, generates annual national press, and anchors its main fundraising gala. An equivalent “robotics/AI pioneers” award could do the same for you — punching far above your size and creating a recurring fundraising event.

11.4 Exhibits & inventory — strong model, but your content diverges

ACRM packs ~4,000 years of invention into a deceptively small, high-density space — signature artifacts include an **Apple I signed and donated by Steve Wozniak**, an Altair 8800 signed by Ed Roberts, an Enigma machine, Apollo-program artifacts, and a first edition of Newton’s *Principia*. It draws ~10,000 visitors/year and tops Bozeman’s TripAdvisor rankings on curation quality, not scale. **What transfers:** density, storytelling, and curation beat square footage. **What you will do differently:** your draw is *live, interactive, AI-driven* lifelike androids — experiences, not glass-case artifacts — which also means higher capital and maintenance costs and a continual-refresh budget that ACRM, with static exhibits, does not carry.

11.5 What to replicate vs. do differently

Replicate from ACRM	Deliberately diverge
Contributions-led funding model (75%+ from donors/members); lean cost discipline; near-zero debt.	Add stronger earned revenue (shows, fleet rentals, premium experiences) to lift the ~10–20% admission ceiling.
Real board + paid director + documented processes from day one (the succession lesson).	Plan for higher operating complexity — robot maintenance, AI guardrails, uptime staff — that a static museum avoids.
A signature annual awards program to attract luminaries, press, and gala revenue.	Lead with live interactivity and refreshable AI content, not a fixed historical collection.
University/tech-employer anchor and community embedding.	Target a larger metro for the foot traffic a high-capital android attraction needs; avoid tourism dependence.

Net: ACRM proves the durability formula for a niche robotics institution — lean governance, disciplined cost control, a marquee awards program, and a university anchor (plus, in its case, philanthropy-led funding). The governance and operating lessons transfer to either structure; only the funding engine changes (investors/earned revenue for a for-profit, donors for a nonprofit). Adopt that

operating backbone, then layer your cutting-edge, interactive AI-android experience on top as the differentiator ACRM never had.

12. Sources

All links are live as of June 2026. Pricing for advanced humanoids (Ameca) is quote-only; ranges above come from secondary reviewers and should be confirmed with the vendor. Market-size figures are vendor estimates presented as ranges; bank and industry-body figures (Goldman, Morgan Stanley, TEA/AECOM, IFR) are the most defensible.

15. [EX Future Science & Technology Museum \(China\)](#)
16. [EX Robots — “Li Bai” talking android \(China Daily\)](#)
17. [Engineered Arts — Madame Tussauds Shanghai figure](#)
18. [Engineered Arts — Ameca](#)
19. [Hanson Robotics — robots](#)
20. [Promobot Robo-C](#)
21. [Henn na Hotel — robots “fired” \(SCMP\)](#)
22. [American Computer & Robotics Museum](#)
23. [Roboland US \(Cleveland\)](#)
24. [The Bilotta Collection](#)
25. [Museum of Science, Boston — Exploring AI](#)
26. [Computer History Museum — exhibits \(Ameca\)](#)
27. [MIT Museum](#)
28. [The Tech Interactive](#)
29. [Kamin Science Center — Robot Hall of Fame \(roboworld closed\)](#)
30. [roboworld retired as planned refresh — director’s reasons \(90.5 WESA\)](#)
31. [Grand Rapids Public Museum — Robot Zoo](#)
32. [Disney — Hall of Presidents](#)
33. [FIRST Robotics](#)
34. [VEX / REC Foundation](#)
35. [Code Ninjas](#)
36. [iD Tech robotics camps](#)
37. [U.S. educational-robot market \(Grand View Research\)](#)
38. [Assoc. of Children’s Museums — education revenue](#)
39. [Titan the Robot \(Cyberstein\)](#)
40. [Scarlett Entertainment — robotics acts](#)
41. [Engineered Arts — rentals](#)
42. [Sphere Las Vegas — Aura robots](#)
43. [Maker Faire — exhibitor/commercial fees](#)

44. [Museum Planner — starting a museum \(costs\)](#)
45. [Museum Planner — exhibit costs](#)
46. [Sotheby's Institute — nonprofit museum business model](#)
47. [AAM — earned income / museum funding](#)
48. [AAM — 2025 visitation recovery](#)
49. [AASLH — top reasons museums close](#)
50. [Robot Restaurant \(Tokyo\) closure](#)
51. [Spyce robotic restaurant closure \(The Robot Report\)](#)
52. [IRS — 501\(c\)\(3\) exempt purposes](#)
53. [Form1023.org — cost to start a 501\(c\)\(3\)](#)
54. [EX Robots "100 museums" expansion \(CGTN\)](#)
55. [Kamin Science Center \\$65M reimagining \(WESA\)](#)
56. [Liberty Science Center expansion \(Jersey Digs\)](#)
57. [Museum of Science Boston — robot interaction \(Boston.com\)](#)
58. [Merlin/Tussauds moving robotic figures](#)
59. [Disney BDX droids — next phase \(Variety\)](#)
60. [Sphere "Aura" humanoid robots](#)
61. [Riyadh "Humanoid Lounge" showroom \(Arab News\)](#)
62. [U.S. consumer/economy outlook 2026 \(Goldman Sachs\)](#)
63. [U.S. economic outlook Q2 2026 \(S&P Global\)](#)
64. [2026 Iran war \(overview\)](#)
65. [Ebola outbreak triggers U.S. travel restrictions \(Scientific American\)](#)
66. [Philanthropy Outlook 2026 \(CCS Fundraising\)](#)
67. [2026 giving outlook \(Foundation Source\)](#)
68. [Foundation giving forecasts 2026 \(Chronicle of Philanthropy\)](#)
69. [ACRM Form 990 financials \(ProPublica, EIN 81-0460318\)](#)
70. [ACRM history & financials \(own 990s + strategic plan\)](#)
71. [ACRM Stibitz-Wilson Awards](#)
72. [ACRM founder succession \(Billings Gazette\)](#)
73. [ACRM-MSU connection \(Montana State University\)](#)
74. [Suzhou Robot Museum \(Engineered Arts\)](#)
75. [Beijing Robot Mall \(Beijing.gov\)](#)
76. [China school AI mandate \(NPR\)](#)
77. [Unitree at CCTV Spring Festival Gala \(SCMP\)](#)
78. [Mirai Ishiguro androids \(New Atlas\)](#)
79. [Hiroshi Ishiguro / Geminoid \(IEEE Spectrum\)](#)
80. [Erica android cast in film \(HuffPost\)](#)
81. [Misora Hibari AI hologram \(Japan Times\)](#)

82. [Henn na Hotel cuts robots \(Hotel Management\)](#)
83. [Seoul Robot & AI Museum \(Visit Seoul\)](#)
84. [Masan Robot Land \(Visit Korea\)](#)
85. [Korea AI celebrity resurrection \(CNN\)](#)
86. [The Robot Museum, Madrid](#)
87. [Science Museum London — Robots](#)
88. [Heinz Nixdorf MuseumsForum](#)
89. [Copernicus Science Centre Robotic Theatre](#)
90. [Deutsches Museum Robotics](#)
91. [Cité des Sciences — Robots](#)
92. [National Robotarium, Edinburgh](#)
93. [Engineered Arts Mesmer](#)
94. [Ai-Da Robot exhibitions](#)
95. [Aldebaran \(Pepper/NAO\) receivership \(Robot Report\)](#)
96. [Dubai Museum of the Future — Ameca \(Blooloop\)](#)
97. [Sophia granted Saudi citizenship \(WEF\)](#)
98. [Saudi humanoids Sara & Mohammad \(IoT World Today\)](#)
99. [RoboCafe Dubai](#)
100. [Saudi PIF HUMAIN launch](#)
101. [TELUS Spark RO5iE robot coaster \(Canada\)](#)
102. [Ontario Science Centre closure \(Wikipedia\)](#)
103. [Questacon robots \(Engineered Arts\)](#)
104. [India Atal Tinkering Labs \(PIB\)](#)
105. [Goldman Sachs — \\$38B humanoid TAM by 2035](#)
106. [Morgan Stanley — \\$5T humanoid market by 2050](#)
107. [Entertainment robots market \(Precedence\)](#)
108. [Educational robots market \(Grand View\)](#)
109. [Service robotics market \(Grand View\)](#)
110. [Museums market \(GMInsights\)](#)
111. [Theme park market \(Grand View\)](#)
112. [Experience economy \(Empower\)](#)
113. [Figure AI Series C / \\$39B valuation](#)
114. [Humanoid VC funding \(Crunchbase\)](#)
115. [Engineered Arts \\$10M raise \(VentureBeat\)](#)
116. [China ~\\$138B robotics investment \(IFR\)](#)
117. [TEA/AECOM 2024 Global Experience Index](#)
118. [World Robot Olympiad](#)
119. [Robotex International](#)

- 120. [DJI RoboMaster](#)
- 121. [Algorithmics \(global franchise\)](#)
- 122. [Makeblock](#)
- 123. [RoboThink franchising](#)
- 124. [World Robot Conference, Beijing](#)
- 125. [World Robot Summit, Japan](#)